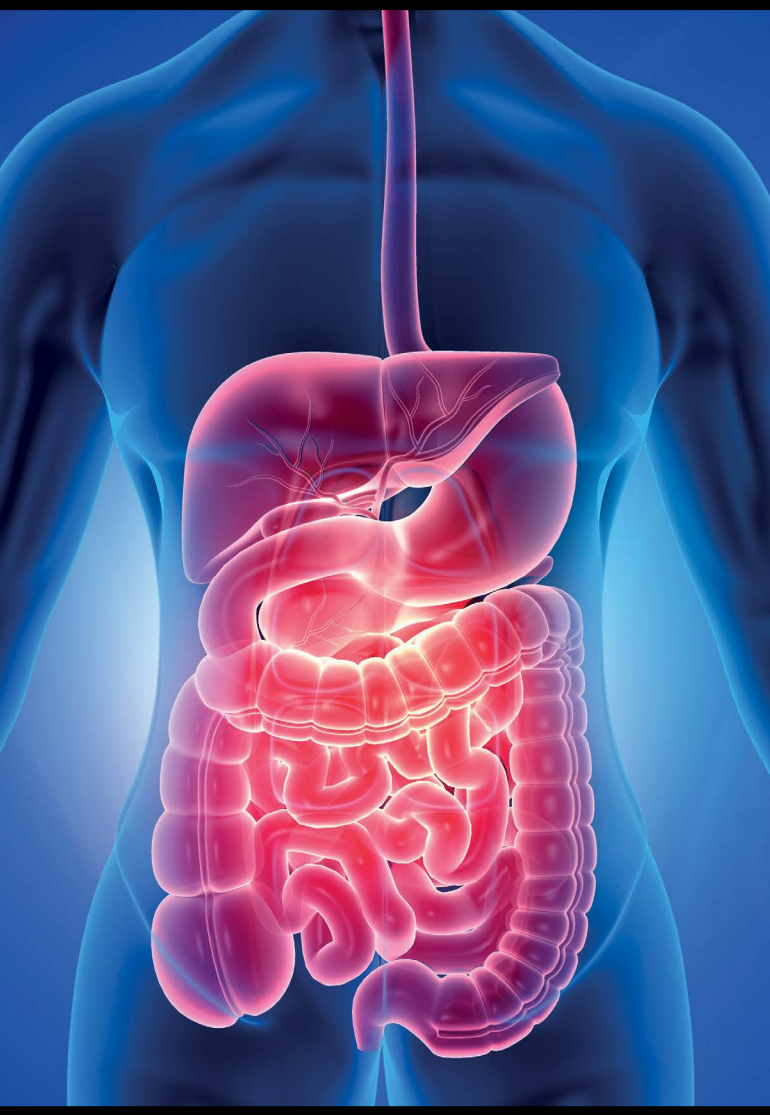


A new trend of taking vibrating capsules to stimulate bowel movements has also shown early results. Probiotics and prebiotics too help reduce symptoms.

3. IBS (Irritable Bowel Syndrome)

Although the exact nature of changes in the gut during IBS is still being investigated, it is usually associated with an overgrowth or imbalance of gut bacteria. Symptoms include stomach pain, bloating, gas, constipation, indigestion

Cause: There is no single cause, but a combination of risk factors including stress, foods that trigger pre-existing allergies, family history, mental disorders and a result of bacterial or parasital infections in the intestines

Treatment: The latest treatment is stool transplant where healthy stool from a donor is transplanted into the patient

4. GRED (Gastro-esophagal Reflux Disease)

A disease in which stomach acid flows back up the oesophagus, accompanied by burning stomach pain, regurgitation of food, sore throat, and difficulty swallowing

Causes: Consuming of too much fatty foods, chocolate, coffee, citrus fruits, anti-inflammatory medicines, stomach ulcer, smoking, over-eating or obesity

Treatment: Serious cases may require transoral incisionless fundoplication to surgically repair the oesophagus via endoscopic technique



"Inflammation in the gut can trigger neuroinflammation, leading to mental health issues. Dysbiosis may also be linked to neurological conditions like anxiety, depression and neurodegenerative diseases"

— DR HARSH SETH

Consultant laparoscopic gastrointestinal surgeon, Wockhardt Hospitals, Mumbai

The Gut-Brain Axis

New research is revealing just how important the gut is not just for our physical health but also our mental well-being. The human brain is said to have 100 billion neurons. But there are 500 million neurons in the human gut, too, and they seem to be in conversation with the brain about everything that goes on in the body, from immunity to sensory perception. The main channel for this communication is the vagus nerve, which carries signals between the brain, the heart and the digestive system; at the latter end, the vagus links to the enteric nervous system (or ENS, a network of nerve cells in the gut). Flitting back and forth between the two, we have the neurotransmitters, which play the part of couriers. So, the thought of your favourite food is communicated along the vagus to the gut. "The ENS has millions of nerve cells in two thin layers in our gastrointestinal tract, from the food pipe to the rectum. It controls digestion, breakdown of food into nutrients, secretion of enzymes and excretion of waste,"